Faith That Pleases God

Faith takes God at his word about what we cannot yet see, and shows itself by trusting obedience.

Main passage	Hebrews 11:1-10 (KJV)
Topic	Faith
Audience	adults
Length	about 45 minutes
Status	Draft: written by AI from the library, not yet reviewed by Dave

Suggested timing

Opening	4 min
Scripture	3 min
Background	5 min
Teaching point 1: Faith trusts what God has said about what we cannot see	7 min
Teaching point 2: Without faith it is impossible to please God	7 min
Teaching point 3: Faith obeys and keeps going	7 min
Discussion questions	7 min
Application	3 min
Closing prayer	2 min
Total	45 min

Opening (4 min)

Ask: "What do you trust every day without seeing it?" (A chair before you sit in it, a bridge, the pilot of a plane, a doctor's prescription.) Then ask: "What makes that trust reasonable?" Usually it is the reliability of the one we are trusting. Faith in the Bible works the same way. Its strength depends on whom it trusts.

Scripture (3 min)

Hebrews 11:1-10

[1] Now faith is the substance of things hoped for, the evidence of things not seen. [2] For by it the elders obtained a good report. [3] Through faith we understand that the worlds were framed by the word of God, so that things which are seen were not made of things which do appear. [4] By faith Abel offered unto God a more excellent sacrifice than Cain, by which he obtained witness that he was righteous, God testifying of his gifts: and by it he being dead yet speaketh. [5] By faith Enoch was translated that he should not see death;

and was not found, because God had translated him: for before his translation he had this testimony, that he pleased God. [6] But without faith it is impossible to please him: for he that cometh to God must believe that he is, and that he is a rewarder of them that diligently seek him. [7] By faith Noah, being warned of God of things not seen as yet, moved with fear, prepared an ark to the saving of his house; by the which he condemned the world, and became heir of the righteousness which is by faith. [8] By faith Abraham, when he was called to go out into a place which he should after receive for an inheritance, obeyed; and he went out, not knowing whither he went. [9] By faith he sojourned in the land of promise, as in a strange country, dwelling in tabernacles with Isaac and Jacob, the heirs with him of the same promise: [10] For he looked for a city which hath foundations, whose builder and maker is God.

Read the passage aloud. As each name comes up (Abel, Enoch, Noah, Abraham), pause to let the class recall in a phrase what that person did.

Background (5 min)

Hebrews was written to Jewish Christians who were under pressure and tempted to give up and go back. Chapter 10 ends, "the just shall live by faith ... we are not of them who draw back" (10:38-39). Chapter 11 then explains what that faith looks like, using a long line of Old Testament believers, often called the "hall of faith."

The writer's point is not that these people were perfect; their stories show many failures. The point is that each one trusted God's word and acted on it before seeing the outcome. Chapter 12 then turns to us: "Seeing we also are compassed about with so great a cloud of witnesses ... let us run with patience" (12:1).

Teacher note: The writer of Hebrews is not named in the letter. Christians have suggested Paul, Apollos, Barnabas and others; the lesson simply says "the writer of Hebrews."

Teaching point 1: Faith trusts what God has said about what we cannot see (7 min)

Verse 1 gives a description of faith: it gives substance to what we hope for and is convinced of what we cannot see. Faith is not wishful thinking. It rests on what God has said. Verse 3 gives the first example. None of us saw the world made, but we believe God made it because he has told us so.

Supporting verses

Hebrews 11:1-3: Now faith is the substance of things hoped for, the evidence of things not seen. For by it the elders obtained a good report. Through faith we understand that the worlds were framed by the word of God, so that things which are seen were not made of things which do appear.

2 Corinthians 5:7: (For we walk by faith, not by sight:)

Romans 10:17: So then faith cometh by hearing, and hearing by the word of God.

> *"We perceive with our spiritual intelligence the fact of the world's creation by God, though we see neither Him nor the act of creation"*

> — Andrew Robert Fausset, Commentary Critical and Explanatory on the Whole Bible (Jamieson, Fausset and Brown), on Hebrews 11:3

Handout blanks (answers)

Faith is the evidence of things not **seen**.

Faith rests on what God has **said**.

Teaching point 2: Without faith it is impossible to please God (7 min)

Abel, Enoch and Noah pleased God because they trusted him. Verse 6 states the principle: whoever comes to God must believe that he exists and that he rewards those who seek him. Faith is more than knowing facts about God. It is coming to him and relying on him.

Supporting verses

Hebrews 11:4-6: By faith Abel offered unto God a more excellent sacrifice than Cain, by which he obtained witness that he was righteous, God testifying of his gifts: and by it he being dead yet speaketh. By faith Enoch was translated that he should not see death; and was not found, because God had translated him: for before his translation he had this testimony, that he pleased God. But without faith it is impossible to please him: for he that cometh to God must believe that he is, and that he is a rewarder of them that diligently seek him.

Romans 4:20-21: He staggered not at the promise of God through unbelief; but was strong in faith, giving glory to God; And being fully persuaded that, what he had promised, he was able also to perform.

James 2:19: Thou believest that there is one God; thou doest well: the devils also believe, and tremble.

> *"Without confidence in God--in his fidelity, his truth, his wisdom, his promises."*
> — Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Hebrews 11:6

> *"But a man may know a thing, and yet not have faith. I may know a thing, and yet not believe it."*
> — C. H. Spurgeon, sermon "Faith"

Handout blanks (answers)

Without faith it is **impossible** to please God.

Faith is not only knowing about God but **trusting** him.

Teacher note: Spurgeon's sermon on Hebrews 11:6 (in the library) works through knowledge, assent and trust as the parts of faith, if the class wants to go deeper.

Teaching point 3: Faith obeys and keeps going (7 min)

Noah built an ark before a drop of rain fell. Abraham left home "not knowing whither he went" (v. 8). He lived in tents in the very land God had promised him. He kept trusting because he was looking beyond this life to "a city which hath foundations, whose builder and maker is God" (v. 10). Real faith moves our feet, and it keeps moving them when the promise is slow in coming.

Supporting verses

Hebrews 11:7-10: By faith Noah, being warned of God of things not seen as yet, moved with fear, prepared an ark to the saving of his house; by the which he condemned the world, and became heir of the righteousness which is by faith. By faith Abraham, when he was called to go out into a place which he should after receive for an inheritance, obeyed; and he went out, not knowing whither he went. By faith he sojourned in the land of promise, as in a strange country, dwelling in tabernacles with Isaac and Jacob, the heirs with him of the same promise: For he looked for a city which hath foundations, whose builder and maker is God.

Genesis 12:1-4: Now the LORD had said unto Abram, Get thee out of thy country, and from thy kindred, and from thy father's house, unto a land that I will shew thee: And I will make of thee a great nation, and I will bless thee, and make thy name great; and thou shalt be a blessing: And I will bless them that bless thee, and curse him that curseth thee: and in thee shall all families of the earth be blessed. So Abram departed, as the LORD had spoken unto him; and Lot went with him: and Abram was seventy and five years old when he departed out of Haran.

Hebrews 11:13-16: These all died in faith, not having received the promises, but having seen them afar off, and were persuaded of them, and embraced them, and confessed that they were strangers and pilgrims on the earth. For they that say such things declare plainly that they seek a country. And truly, if they had been mindful of that country from whence they came out, they might have had opportunity to have returned. But now they desire a better country, that is, an heavenly: wherefore God is not ashamed to be called their God: for he hath prepared for them a city.

> *"his obedience was the fullest proof of his faith in God"*
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Hebrews 11:8

> *"He knew that earth could afford no permanent residence for an immortal mind, and he looked for that heavenly building of which God is the architect and owner"*
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Hebrews 11:10

Handout blanks (answers)

Abraham went out, not knowing **whither (where)** he went.

Faith shows itself in trusting **obedience**.

Discussion questions (7 min)

1. How would you explain the difference between faith and wishful thinking?

Wishful thinking rests on what we want; faith rests on what God has said and on his proven character.

2. Why do you think the writer chose people whose stories include failures?

To show that faith is trust in God, not human perfection. God works through ordinary, flawed people who rely on him.

3. Noah and Abraham acted before they saw anything happen. Where is God asking you to trust him before you see the outcome?

Answers will vary (a decision, a relationship, giving, a move, an illness).

4. Abraham looked for a heavenly city. How does hope for the future help us keep trusting now?

Knowing God's promises reach beyond this life gives patience when earthly circumstances disappoint.

Application (3 min)

Write down one promise of God that speaks to a situation you are facing (for example Philippians 4:19, Isaiah 41:10, or Romans 8:28). Read it every morning this week. Then take one concrete step of obedience that shows you are trusting it.

Closing prayer (2 min)

Faithful God, you have spoken, and your word does not fail. Strengthen our faith where it is weak. Help us trust you with what we cannot see, obey you when we do not know where the road leads, and keep looking to the city you are preparing. Through Jesus Christ, the author and finisher of our faith, Amen.

Sources quoted

Andrew Robert Fausset, Commentary Critical and Explanatory on the Whole Bible (Jamieson, Fausset and Brown), on Hebrews 11:3

Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Hebrews 11:6

C. H. Spurgeon, sermon “Faith”

Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Hebrews 11:8

Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Hebrews 11:10

Every quotation was checked word for word against the library text it cites. All sources are in the public domain.